A Triumph of Surgery

The big idea

A Triumph of Surgery by **James Herriot**, a veterinary surgeon in Yorkshire, England, is a humorous story about **Tricki Woo**, a pampered Pekinese dog, who falls ill because his rich owner, **Mrs Pumphrey**, overfeeds him. The "cure" is not surgery at all but simple **diet and exercise**.

Summary

- **The problem:** Mrs Pumphrey is a wealthy lady who loves Tricki so much that she feeds him far too much — **malt, cod-liver oil, Horlicks** at night, **cream cakes and chocolates**. Tricki becomes hugely fat "like a bloated sausage", **listless**, refuses food, and has **bloodshot eyes** and a lolling tongue.
- **First advice:** Herriot (the narrator) advises **cutting down food and more exercise**, but Mrs Pumphrey cannot resist Tricki's pleading eyes and does not follow it.
- **Taking Tricki away:** When Tricki becomes seriously ill, Herriot insists he must be taken to the **surgery (the vet's hospital)** for **two weeks** for observation. Mrs Pumphrey is heartbroken and sends him with his bed, toys, cushions, coats and dinner bowls.
- **The treatment:** At the surgery, Tricki gets **no food for two days — only water**. Then he is let loose with the other dogs; he plays, runs and joins the pack at mealtime, fighting for his share. He becomes lively and healthy.
- **The gifts:** Thinking Tricki needs strength, Mrs Pumphrey sends **fresh eggs** (two dozen at a time), and later **bottles of wine and brandy**. Herriot and his partners enjoy them — Herriot admits feeling a little guilty.
- **The return:** Tricki returns fit and leaps into his owner's arms. Mrs Pumphrey, with tears in her eyes, calls it **"a triumph of surgery"**.

THE IRONY OF THE TITLE

No surgery was performed. The "triumph" was simply a healthy diet and exercise — the irony makes the title humorous.

Characters

Character	Traits
Mrs Pumphrey	rich, kind, loving but **foolish** and over-indulgent; treats Tricki like a child
Tricki Woo	lovable, pampered Pekinese; becomes active once away from luxury
James Herriot	sensible, professional, patient, humorous; honest enough to admit he enjoyed the gifts

HERRIOT DID NOT OPERATE ON TRICKI

The word "surgery" in British English also means a **doctor's or vet's clinic**. That double meaning is the joke.

Themes and value points

- **Over-indulgence** harms; love must be sensible.
- Pets (and children) need discipline, the right diet and exercise.
- A good professional is firm with the owner but gentle with the patient.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why was Tricki ill? Was Mrs Pumphrey a sensible owner? Why did Herriot take Tricki to the surgery? What were the gifts? Why is the title ironic? Do you think Herriot was right to enjoy the gifts?

Quick recap

- James Herriot; Tricki Woo (Pekinese); Mrs Pumphrey.
- Overfeeding → illness; diet and exercise at the surgery → recovery.
- Eggs, wine and brandy enjoyed by the vets.
- "A triumph of surgery" — ironic, because no surgery was done.

Practice questions

1. Why was Tricki ill?

   (a) He had an infection (b) He was overfed and got no exercise (c) He was bitten by another dog (d) He had eaten poison

2. What breed was Tricki?

   (a) Spaniel (b) Terrier (c) Bulldog (d) Pekinese

3. What treatment did Herriot give Tricki at first in the surgery?

   (a) An operation (b) Many medicines (c) No food for two days, only water (d) Extra cod-liver oil

4. What did Mrs Pumphrey send to the surgery for Tricki?

   (a) Eggs, wine and brandy (b) Medicines and syringes (c) Only toys (d) Chocolates and cakes

5. Why is the title ironic?

   (a) Herriot failed in the surgery (b) Tricki died (c) No surgery was performed; diet and exercise cured him (d) Mrs Pumphrey was a surgeon

6. How long did Tricki stay at the surgery?

   (a) Two days (b) Two months (c) One day (d) About two weeks

7. Compare and contrast the attitudes of Mrs Pumphrey and Dr Herriot towards Tricki.

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. c 4. a 5. c 6. d 7. see notes